

Lighting

The one variable that determines whether a photo looks professional

Good lighting covers a lot of mistakes. Bad lighting exposes everything. I've seen expensive cameras produce mediocre photos because the lighting was wrong, and I've seen the opposite. Lighting is the variable with the highest leverage — get it right and everything else becomes easier.

Window Light

Indirect window light — daylight bounced off clouds or walls, not direct sun — is genuinely beautiful for portraits. Soft, even, and flattering. The problem is it changes constantly. Professional shoots use it where it works and supplement it where it doesn't.

Mixed Light Sources

This is where most DIY shoots go wrong. Fluorescent overhead lights and daylight from a window have completely different color temperatures. Your camera has to pick one to expose correctly, and the other looks wrong. Controlling or matching the sources fixes this.

Three-Point Setup

A main light, a fill to soften the shadows it creates, and a backlight to separate the subject from the background. This is the standard for a reason — it produces consistent, three-dimensional results that on-camera flash can't come close to.

Golden Hour for Exteriors

The hour after sunrise and before sunset produces warm, directional light that's almost impossible to replicate artificially. For exterior shots — storefronts, outdoor spaces — timing around golden hour is one of the simplest things you can do to dramatically change the result.

BEFORE I SHOW UP

I scout the space in advance — figure out where the good light is, what time it hits, and what I'll need to bring. Time on location is spent shooting, not problem-solving.
